

VEER

Letters, Emails, and Awkward Messages

The complaint, the condolence, the boundary, and the one you've been putting off.

You are here

By the end of this guide you'll be able to:

Understand why the hard ones are hard — and why staring at them doesn't help.

Write a complaint that gets a result without burning the relationship.

Say no clearly, kindly, and in three sentences instead of eleven.

Write a condolence message without the fear of getting it wrong stopping you.

Ask for money you're owed without the embarrassment leaking into the wording.

Set a boundary with someone you can't simply avoid.

Steal from twelve finished messages at the back, each with the request that produced it.

This is the book for the message that's been sitting in your drafts for three days.

01

Why the hard ones are hard

Notice which messages you put off. Never the easy ones — never confirming a time or thanking someone for lunch. It's always the complaint, the refusal, the condolence, the one about money.

It's tempting to think the problem is finding the right words. It isn't. You could write any of those messages in ninety seconds if the wording were the difficulty.

The difficulty is that you're doing three things at once. You're trying to get an outcome, protect a relationship, and manage your own discomfort — and those three pull in different directions. Being firmer helps the outcome and risks the relationship. Being warmer protects the relationship and weakens the outcome.

That's why staring at the blank box doesn't work. You're not stuck for words. You're stuck on a judgement you haven't made yet.

Which is exactly what this is useful for. Describing the situation out loud — who they are, what happened, what you're afraid of, what you actually want — forces the judgement into the open. Half the time you'll realise what you want to say while you're typing the description.

THE THING WORTH NOTICING

People who use this well for difficult messages rarely say "write me a complaint." They describe the situation the way they'd describe it to a friend, and the message falls out of that.

Try this now. Think of the message you've been avoiding. Say out loud what you're actually worried will happen. That sentence is the most important thing you'll type.

02

Tell it the relationship first

Every lesson after this one depends on this one.

The same facts produce completely different messages depending on who's involved. "The heating is broken and hasn't been fixed" is one message to a letting agency you'll never meet, and an entirely different message to a landlord who lives next door and lends you his ladder.

So lead with the relationship, before the facts.

Four things, and you can say them in a sentence each:

Who they are to you. Neighbour, boss, sister, stranger at a company, someone you'll see every Sunday for the next twenty years.

How things stand. Warm, cool, fine until this, already strained, never met.

What you're protecting. *I still have to work with him. I don't want a feud. I'd like to be invited next year.*

What you're prepared to risk. Sometimes the honest answer is nothing. Sometimes it's the relationship. Both are useful to say.

That fourth one is the one people leave out, and it's the one that decides the tone.

Try this now. Write those four sentences about your avoided message before you ask for anything.

03

The complaint that gets a result

Most complaints fail in one of two directions. Too soft and it reads as a query, gets filed, and nothing happens. Too hot and the person reading it stops being on your side — and it's almost always a person, usually one who didn't cause your problem.

The shape that works has four parts, in this order:

What happened. Facts and dates. No adjectives.

What you've already done. Dates again. This is what turns a request into a pattern.

What you want. Specifically. A replacement, a refund, a visit on a named day.

By when. A real date, not "urgently."

What to leave out, because all of it costs you:

Sarcasm. It reads as unserious and gives them a reason to dislike you.

Threats you won't carry out. "I'll take this further" from someone who won't is obvious, and it moves you from reasonable to noisy.

The full history. Three sentences of background, not three paragraphs. Long complaints get skimmed, and skimming loses your specific ask.

Anger at the reader. They didn't build the dishwasher. Someone who feels blamed defends themselves instead of helping you.

THE LINE THAT DOES THE MOST WORK

"I'd like to sort this out with you rather than take it further." It's warm, it's honest, and it makes the easy path the one you want.

Try this now. Take a complaint you're sitting on and write only the four parts. Nothing else.

04

Saying no

The message people avoid most, and the one that gets longest when they finally write it.

Length is the tell. A long no reads as guilt, and guilt invites negotiation — every extra sentence of explanation is another handle for someone to pull on. Nine sentences of reasoning gets you a follow-up asking whether you could manage a smaller version. Three sentences doesn't.

A good no has three parts and stops:

The no. Early, and unmistakably a no. Not "I'm not sure I can."

One reason, or none. A short true one. You don't owe a case.

What you can offer, if anything. Optional. Only if you mean it.

Don't apologise more than once. One "sorry" reads as considerate. Three reads as an opening.

Don't invent a reason. Invented reasons expire, and then you're managing a fiction. "I can't take this on at the moment" needs no scaffolding.

Don't leave a door open you want shut. "Maybe next time" said out of politeness produces exactly the same conversation in six weeks.

THE THREE-SENTENCE NO

Thanks for thinking of me. I'm not going to be able to take this on. I hope it goes really well.

That's a complete, kind, final message. Most people's version of it runs to two hundred words and lands worse.

Try this now. Write a no you've been avoiding in three sentences. Notice the urge to add a fourth. Don't.

05

The condolence

The hardest one, and the one most often not sent at all — which is the worst outcome available.

People freeze because they're afraid of saying the wrong thing. Worth knowing: the wrong thing, sent, is almost always better received than nothing. Grieving people remember who reached out. They rarely remember the wording.

What tends to land:

Something specific about the person. One memory, one detail, one thing you liked about them. This is the whole message, really.

Plain acknowledgement. "I'm so sorry." You don't need a better phrase; there isn't one.

A concrete offer, or none at all. "I'll drop a meal round on Thursday unless you'd rather I didn't" is worth more than "let me know if you need anything," which puts the work on them.

What tends to hurt, however well meant:

Comparisons. "I know exactly how you feel, when my father died..." turns their loss into your story.

Silver linings. "At least it was quick." "She had a good innings." These are usually said to relieve the speaker's discomfort.

Anything about a plan or a purpose, unless you know for certain they'd want it.

SHORT IS NOT A FAILURE HERE

Four sentences, sent within the week, saying one true specific thing about the person who died, is a good condolence message. Length is not the measure. Sending it is.

Try this now. If someone's been on your mind, describe them in one sentence and go from there.

06

Chasing what you're owed

Money changes the register of a message, and the embarrassment usually leaks into the wording. It comes out as over-apologising, vagueness about the amount, or a joke that makes it easy to keep ignoring.

Separate the relationship from the transaction. Warm about the person, precise about the number. Those aren't in tension — being vague isn't kind, it extends the awkwardness.

Name the amount and the date. Not "the money" — the figure, and when it was due.

Assume it was an oversight. Give them a way to pay without an admission.

Make paying easy. Details in the message. Remove every step.

Say what happens next. One line, unemotional.

WITH A BUSINESS

Invoice 214 for £480 was due on the 3rd. I don't think I've had payment — could you let me know when it's going out? Bank details are below in case they're helpful.

WITH A FRIEND

Hello — sorry to be the person who brings this up. The £150 from the tickets in March is still outstanding. No rush this week, but could you send it over when you get a chance?

Neither is angry, both name the figure, and both are easier to answer than to ignore. That's the whole design.

Try this now. Write the one-line version with the number in it. That line is the message; everything else is packaging.

07

Setting a boundary

Different from a complaint, and the difference is the whole lesson.

A complaint asks someone to fix something. A boundary tells someone what *you* will do. That distinction matters because you can't enforce a request — but you can always keep to your own decision.

"Could you stop dropping in unannounced?" is a request. It can be forgotten, negotiated, or ignored.

"I'm not going to answer the door if I'm not expecting anyone — do give me a ring first." is a boundary. Nothing to agree to, nothing to argue with.

Write it in the present tense, about yourself. Not what they must stop; what you now do.

Don't build a case. Reasons invite debate. A boundary isn't a proposal, and a paragraph of justification quietly turns it into one.

Expect one round of pushback. Repeat the same sentence, warmly, without new arguments. Adding arguments signals the position is available for negotiation.

Say the warm thing too, if it's true. "I love it when you visit, and I need a bit of notice" is a boundary. It's no softer for being kind.

WHERE THIS STOPS BEING A WORDING PROBLEM

Some situations aren't a phrasing failure — they're a relationship in real trouble, or something that needs someone else involved. If a message feels frightening rather than awkward, that's a signal to talk to a person you trust rather than a better draft.

Try this now. Take a request you've been making and rewrite it as something you'll do.

08

Making it sound like you

The most common disappointment: the message is correct, does everything you asked, and doesn't sound remotely like you. Then you spend twenty minutes rewriting it, which was what you were avoiding.

Stop describing your voice and show it. "Write it in my tone" means almost nothing. Paste in two messages you actually sent and liked, and say *match how these sound*. One real example teaches it more than any adjective.

Name the words you'd never use. Everyone has them. *Reach out. Circle back. I hope this finds you well. Delighted. Utilise.* Say so, and they vanish.

Say how you actually start and finish. People's openings and sign-offs are the most recognisable part of how they write, and the most likely to come out generic.

Read it aloud. The fastest test there is. Anything you'd never say out loud, cut. This catches almost everything.

THE TWO-LINE FIX

Add to any request: "Here are two messages I've sent before — match this voice. I'd never say 'reach out' or 'I hope this finds you well.'"

Try this now. Find two messages you were happy with. Keep them somewhere. That's your voice sample from now on.

09

The last read before you send

Never send the first version of a difficult message. Not because it'll be bad — because five things are almost always worth changing, and they take a minute.

Cut the first sentence. It's usually throat-clearing. Messages nearly always improve when they start one sentence later.

Delete "I just wanted to." It shrinks whatever comes after it. So does "sorry to bother you" and "quick question."

Count the apologies. More than one and you sound like you did something wrong.

Find the actual ask and move it up. In difficult messages the request tends to drift to the end, after the explanation. Put it in the first two sentences. People stop reading.

Check it isn't warmer than you are. If the tone is friendlier than you feel, you'll resent the reply. Match the message to where you actually stand.

THE FINAL TEST

Read it as though you received it. Would you know what you were being asked for, and would you feel accused? Those two questions catch nearly everything worth catching.

Try this now. Take any draft and apply all five. It takes about a minute and it's the highest-value minute in this book.

Twelve messages you can steal

The rest of this book is finished messages. Each one shows the request that produced it and the message that came back.

They're here to be taken and adapted, not admired. Change the names, change the details, change the tone — the point is that you start from something rather than from a blank box.

Every one of them follows a lesson. If a message here does something you can't see the reason for, the lesson it came from will explain it.

1 • A repair that keeps failing

THE ASK

Write a complaint to a letting agency. The boiler has broken three times since November and been "fixed" twice. I've reported it on the 4th, the 19th and yesterday. I want a replacement rather than a third repair, and someone out this week. I still have to deal with these people, so firm but not hostile. Under 180 words.

WHAT CAME BACK

Dear Northgate Lettings,

I'm writing about the boiler at 14 Ashfield Road, which has now failed three times since November. I reported it on 4 November, 19 December, and again yesterday. It has been repaired twice, and has failed again on each occasion.

I'd like to ask for a replacement rather than a third repair, and for an engineer to attend this week. Three failures in four months suggests the unit itself is the problem.

I'd rather sort this out with you directly than take it further. Could you confirm by Friday what you're able to do?

Many thanks,

2 · Saying no to extra work

THE ASK

Help me turn down running a committee at work. My manager asked, I don't have capacity, and I've said yes to things like this twice before and regretted it. I don't want to damage the relationship. Three or four sentences, no invented excuse.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hi Ruth,

Thanks for thinking of me for this — I know it matters.

I'm not going to be able to take it on this time. My current workload is already at the limit of what I can do properly, and I'd rather say that now than let it slip later in the year.

Happy to help whoever does take it on get up to speed.

3 · Saying no to family

THE ASK

Help me tell my sister I can't host Christmas this year. I've done it four years running. She'll be disappointed and may push back. I want to be kind and completely final. Short.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hi Kate,

I've been thinking about Christmas and I'm not going to host this year. Four years running has caught up with me and I'd like a quieter one.

I know that's not the answer you were hoping for, and I'm sorry to shift it. I'd love to come to you or to Mum's if either works.

Let me know what you'd like to do.

4 • A condolence to a colleague

THE ASK

Help me write to a colleague whose mother has died. We work closely and get on, but I never met her mother. I don't want to be formal or use stock phrases. Four or five sentences.

WHAT CAME BACK

Dear Tom,

I was so sorry to hear about your mum. I know how much you were looking forward to her coming down at Easter.

I won't pretend to know what this is like, and I'm not going to fill your inbox. I only wanted you to know I'm thinking of you.

I'm covering the Thursday meeting for as long as you need. Don't give it a thought.

5 • Chasing an invoice

THE ASK

Write a polite chase for an unpaid invoice. Invoice 214, £480, due on the 3rd, now eighteen days late. They're a good client and I'd like to keep them. Assume it's an oversight. Short, and make it easy to pay.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hello Priya,

Hope things are going well at your end.

I don't think invoice 214 has come through yet — £480, dated 3 March. I'm assuming it's slipped through rather than anything else.

Could you let me know when it's likely to go out? Bank details are on the invoice, and I'm happy to resend it if that's easier.

Thanks very much,

6 • Money owed by a friend

THE ASK

Help me ask a friend for £150 she owes me from concert tickets in March. It's now July. I've mentioned it twice, jokily, and nothing has happened. I hate this. I want to be direct without making it a thing.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hi Sam,

Slightly awkward one, sorry — the £150 for the March tickets is still outstanding.

I've mentioned it in passing a couple of times and I think it's probably fallen off both our radars, so I thought I'd say it properly instead.

No rush this week, but could you send it across when you get a minute? Same bank details as before.

See you Saturday.

7 • A boundary with a relative

THE ASK

Help me set a boundary with my father-in-law, who turns up unannounced two or three times a week. I like him. I don't want a row, and I do want it to stop. Frame it as what I'm going to do rather than what he must stop doing.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hi David,

We love having you round — genuinely, and I hope you know that.

One thing though: with work and the children we've got much less slack in the week than we used to, and unplanned visits are catching us at bad moments.

From now on we're going to keep to visits we've arranged in advance. Give us a ring or a text and we'll sort a time — you're welcome any time we've planned it.

Hope that's alright.

8 • Noise from a neighbour

THE ASK

Write a note to the neighbours about music late at night. It's been going on for about a month, three or four nights a week, past midnight. I've never spoken to them. I want to stay on good terms — we share a wall and I'm not moving.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hello,

I'm Anna from number 42 — we haven't met properly yet.

I wanted to mention, in the friendliest possible way, that we can hear music through the wall fairly late on some nights, usually past midnight. Our bedroom backs onto your living room, which I suspect is the problem rather than the volume.

Would it be possible to bring it down a bit after eleven? Very happy to come and say hello properly and work out what does and doesn't carry.

Thanks so much,

9 · A genuine apology

THE ASK

Help me apologise to a friend. I forgot her fortieth after saying I'd be there. There is no excuse — I got the date wrong in my diary. I want to apologise without over-explaining or making her manage my guilt.

WHAT CAME BACK

Ellie,

I'm so sorry I missed Saturday. I had the wrong date in my diary, which is entirely my fault and not much of an excuse for your fortieth.

I'm not going to write you a long thing about how bad I feel — that would make it about me. I'm sorry. I should have been there.

I'd love to take you out properly, whenever suits. Say the word.

10 • Declining a wedding invitation

THE ASK

Help me decline a wedding invitation. It's abroad, in August, and I can't afford it. We're close and I don't want her to think I don't care. I'd rather be honest about the money than invent something.

WHAT CAME BACK

Hannah,

Thank you so much for the invitation — I was thrilled to open it.

I'm so sorry, but I'm not going to be able to make it. Honestly, it's the cost of getting out there in August; I've looked at it every way round and I can't make it work this year.

I'm gutted to miss it. Could we do something properly before you go — dinner, my treat, so I can celebrate with you?

All my love,

11 • Asking for a reference

THE ASK

Help me ask a former manager for a reference. I left that job on slightly awkward terms two years ago — I resigned quickly and I don't think she was impressed. I need to acknowledge that without grovelling.

WHAT CAME BACK

Dear Sarah,

I hope you're well, and I hope this isn't out of the blue.

I'm applying for an operations role and I'd like to ask whether you'd be willing to act as a reference. I'm conscious I left at short notice two years ago and that it can't have been convenient at the time — I've thought about that since.

If you'd rather not, I completely understand and there's no need to reply.

With thanks either way,

12 • Ending a lending pattern

THE ASK

Help me tell my brother I can't keep lending him money. It's happened four times in two years and none of it has come back. I love him. I don't want this to become the whole relationship. Firm, warm, and not a lecture.

WHAT CAME BACK

Mark,

I've been thinking about how to say this and there isn't a clever way, so I'll say it plainly.

I'm not going to be able to lend you money any more. It's happened a few times now, and I've noticed it's becoming the thing we talk about — which I don't want, because I'd much rather just have my brother.

That's not me being annoyed with you. It's me trying to keep the rest of it intact.

I'm around this weekend if you fancy a pint.

When it goes wrong

"It's far too formal." Almost always because the relationship wasn't described. Add one line about who they are and how you talk to each other, then ask again in the same conversation.

"It's too apologetic." Say so directly: *one apology only, and cut anything that sounds like I'm asking permission.*

"It sounds like a template." You described your tone instead of showing it. Paste in two real messages and say *match these*.

"It's much too long." Give it a number. *Under 120 words*. Length is the instruction people most often leave out.

"It won't be firm enough." Tell it what you're prepared to risk. Firmness follows from stakes, and it will stay cautious if you haven't said you're willing to be direct.

"It made up details I didn't give it." It fills gaps when it doesn't have facts. Give it the dates and figures, and say *don't invent anything I haven't told you*. Always read a finished message for details you never supplied.

"I've written it and I still can't send it." Then the problem was never the wording. Ask it to help you work out what you're actually worried will happen — that's Lesson 1, and it's usually the real blockage.

THE GENERAL RULE

Almost every bad message here comes from a missing relationship, a missing length, or a missing example of your voice. Add whichever one is absent before rewriting anything.

If you only do one thing

Take one habit and leave the other eight.

Describe the relationship before you describe the problem.

One or two sentences: who they are to you, how things stand, and what you're trying to protect. Before any facts, any dates, any request.

Every difficult message is a judgement about a relationship wearing the costume of a wording problem. Give it the relationship and it can make the judgement with you. Withhold it and you'll get something technically correct that you'd never actually send.

That single habit is most of this book.

Do this next

Want your own requests to land first time? → Asking Better Questions — the four things that turn a generic answer into a useful one, with twelve before-and-afters.

Cautious about what you're pasting in? → Is This Safe? — what it can and can't see, and the short list of things never to type. Worth reading before you paste a letter with your address on it.

Still finding your feet? → Claude for Absolute Beginners — the account, the screen, and the ten habits that make it work.

Want ideas across the rest of life? → 101 Everyday Things to Ask Claude.

The Everyday Claude Guides — start where you are.

DISCLAIMER

This is an independent educational guide created by Veer. It is not affiliated with, authorized by, sponsored by, or endorsed by Anthropic PBC. "Claude" and "Anthropic" are trademarks of Anthropic PBC, used here for identification and descriptive purposes only. All product features, model names, pricing, and interfaces described are those of Anthropic and are subject to change; verify current details at the official source.

This guide reflects the author's own methods and opinions. Nothing in it is legal, medical, or financial advice. The example messages are illustrations written for this book; the names, figures and situations in them are invented.

© 2026 Veer. Personal-use license — for your own use; please don't redistribute or resell.